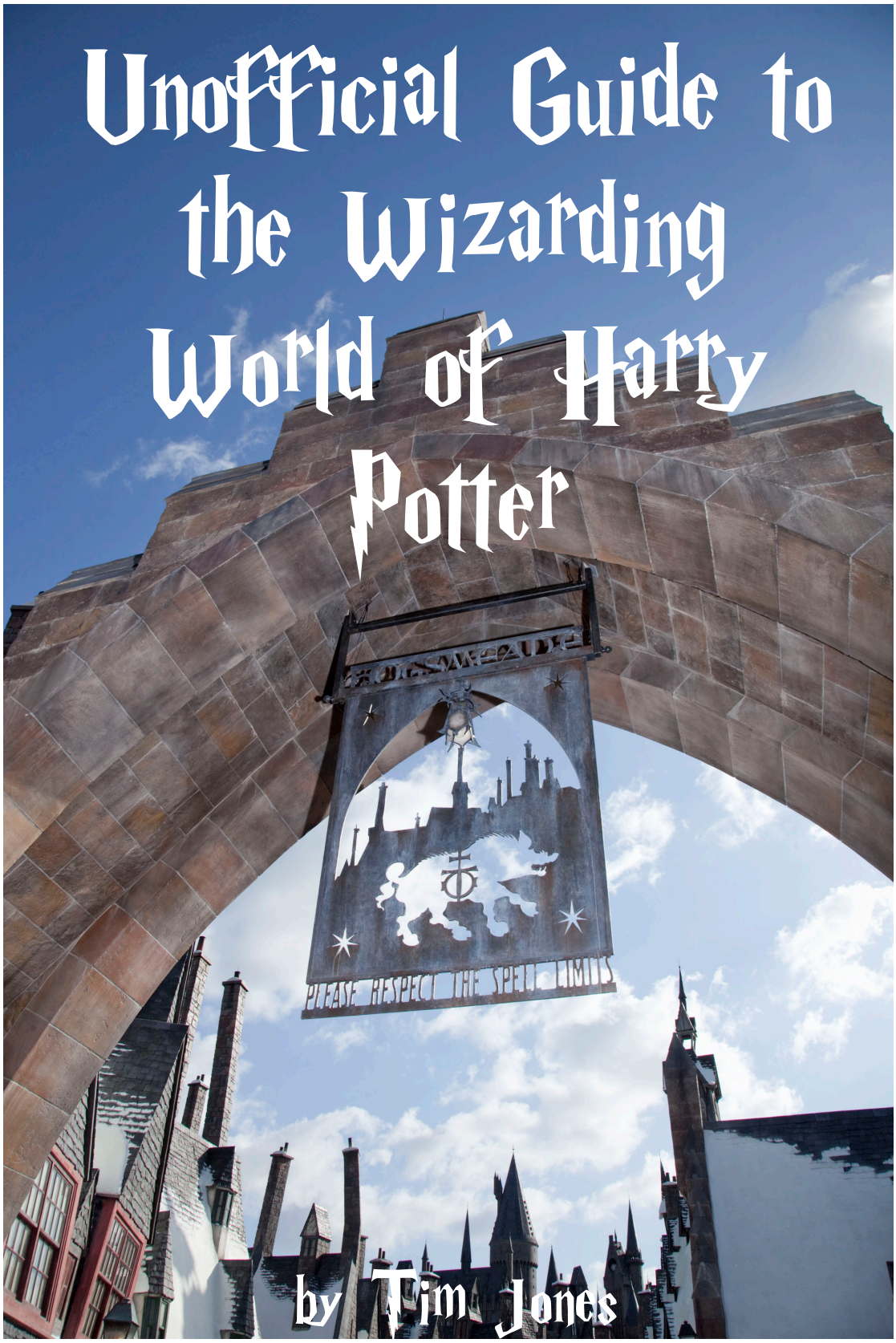
Unofficial Guide to the Wizarding World of Harry Potter



by Tim Jones

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Introduction

The new Wizarding World of Harry Potter puts you in the middle of your favorite Harry Potter movie or book. From the Three Broomsticks to the Butterbeer to Hogwart's and the Frog Choir, it is an amazing new island with magic around every corner.

One of the best things about the new Harry Potter park is that the show never seems to end! Everywhere you look, there's some moving animatronics character, live character shows and performances, a ride, scenes from the books, and so on. This includes both inside the retail locations and attractions, but also out in the "streets." You're continually entertained and made to feel like you've truly entered the world of Harry Potter.

In this book, we'll explore Hogsmeade Village, all of the shops, dining, rides, and attractions. You'll have a wand selected for you, ride a broomstick, drink some butterbeer, and fly on a hippogriff.

The Wizarding World of Harry Potter is located at Universal Orlando's Islands of Adventure park between the islands called Lost Continent and Jurassic Park. When you walk into this island, you are immersed into the world of Harry Potter. You will not see any of the attractions or islands outside this island or even hotels around Orlando. Once you walk through these gates, you are fully immersed in the Wizarding World of Harry Potter. As you leave Lost Continent (the "proper" entrance to this island), you will go through gates with a huge sign hanging that says "Please obey the spell limits."

ATTRACTIONS

Hogsmeade Village

After you pass these gates, you are in Hogsmeade Village. You immediately, see the Hogsmeade Express with live billowing smoke every few minutes. Be sure to stop and have your picture taken with the conductor, standing by for the next train arrival. You will gasp at the Hogsmeade Village which seems to go on endlessly with white capped snow covered roofs that glisten during the day. The buildings are stores and store fronts and windows with a yellow glow on the second floor.

Slow down and take it all in. There's something going on in almost every one of these windows, on the first and second story. You must watch carefully, as some of the "activities" occur only occasionally.

One of the first things you will notice after the Hogwart's Express train are the lockers on your right hand side. You can save yourself a lot of time on many of the rides by putting any bags in here, now. You will have to pay to leave them for more than an hour, but it may be worth it in time saved.

Continuing past the lockers, you'll see Dragon Challenge on your right and in front of you, slightly to the right is the Owlery. This is the home of the Owls from the Owl Post, but it's also a great place to grab a seat and cool off. It has ceiling fans and a small merchandise cart where you can pick up a few souvenirs without going inside the very small Dervish & Banges to fight that crowd. We've also found the Owlery a great place to find shelter from the more than occasional afternoon Florida downpours.

Past the Owlery on the right, you'll pass Ollivander's and likely see the line to get in, first. We'll come back to that line, as well as talk about how to avoid it altogether. Walking past a large archway on your right, you'll see a big open area with an obelisk of sorts. This is where you can see the Frog Choir perfrom, as well as the Beauxbaton girls and Durmstrang boys.

Coming back down the opposite side of the street (the left side as you enter Hogsmeade Village -- now on your right going back down the street), pay particular attention to the second floor of the storefronts. Lots of activity in these windows gets missed by most guests. You'll pass the restrooms on the right. Make sure to stop, even if you don't have to "go" and you'll get a visit from Moaning Myrtle! You'll pass the Hogshead and Three Broomsticks (we'll come back to these in the dining section), but don't miss the full motion wanted poster for Sirius Black in the Three Broomsticks courtyard.

Finally, you'll find yourself back at the main entrance to the island. Now, we'll begin going through the shops and other attractions.

Zonko's Joke Shop

We'll begin our tour of the shops and attractions with Zonko's Joke Shop. This is the first store you'll see as you enter the park on your left hand side. Zonko's has all kinds of pranks and jokes to fill every desire for revenge and practical jokes. You can pick up all kinds of products at Zonko's, including Sneakscope, Extentable Ears, Screaming Yo-yos, a Boxing telescope, Fanged Flyer, Pygmy Puff, Shrunken Heads and more. They also have a giant bell that you can "ring for service." One thing to note, this is where you'll find some of the most unique shirts in the entire Wizarding World.

Honeydukes

Right next to Zonko's -- in fact, you don't even have to go outside -- is Honeydukes Candy shop. It has all the favorite candies of the Harry Potter characters, including chocolate frogs with a wizard trading card and Bertie Bott's Every Flavour Beans. This is the largest of all the stores in the Wizarding World of Harry Potter with aisles and aisles of candy. It's also one of the least crowded shops, usually. You can sneak in here to get a bottle of juice, including the pumpkin variety in a commemorative bottle....or just to cool off a bit.

Ollivander's Wand Shop

Next, we'll wander down to the other end of Diagon Alley to Ollivander's Wand Shop. You won't be able to miss this one, in spite of it's diminutive nature, as there will be a long line outside the door. As we noted earlier, we'll give you some great tips and tricks to avoid or reduce this line in the tips and tricks section. For now, we'll just give you a brief tour.

Ollivander is the shopkeeper of the wand shop where the wizards and witches of Hogsmeade Village get their wands. Ollivander remembers every wand he's ever sold, after each person goes through a rigorous selection process. Guests to the Wizarding World of Harry Potter get to go through this same selection process -- hence the long line. The participant is selected at random, but I've noticed that it's often a child that is somewhere near the front and center.

Ollivander's shop is filled with wands in their boxes, just as you've seen in the movies. The artists did a fantastic job re-creating this shop and it's a crowd favorite. You can look around a bit while you're in here for the show, but not much. Be sure to look up. The shelves seem to go on forever.

One other note: it's very hard to get photos in this shop, due to the darkness. It's one of the places you may want to have a tripod, if you want to get good pictures of your tyke, should they be chosen to go through the selection process. Or, if you just want a picture of you and "Ollivander" at the counter.

After the show, you'll be asked to follow the new wand owner into the Owl Post. Please note: Even if you're the chosen person to go through the selection process, you will not receive a free wand. You'll still have to pay for it.

TIP: If you don't want to go through the line to buy a wand, you can go through the Owl Post entrance, the main Dervish & Banges entrance, and there's also a little known back entrance to Dervish & Banges in the exit queue for Dragon Challenge.

Through any of these doors, you can get into the Owl Post, where all the wands are actually sold. Ollivander's Wand Shop is technically a show, only.

Owl Post

After the Ollivander's show, you'll be escorted through a door and into the Owl Post. As we noted above, this is where you'll actually buy a wand. The wands come in a few varieties. You have the "character" wands that are reproductions of the character's wands from the movies, you have the "Ollivanders" wands that have names like reed, ivy, willow, birch, and so on. These are the wands used in the selection show. Finally, you have wands with LED lights on the tip. These wands are about $10 more and require AA batteries that are not included.

Owl Post is also home to owl postage supplies and other writing implements or supplies. Be sure to look up and see the animatronic owls that call this shop home.

Owl Post is also where you will get your Hogsmeade postage and stamps! Not only can you get USPS stamps with Wizarding World of Harry Potter themes, you can also have your postcards and letters stamped with the Owl Post postage stamp. Just ask for this when you pay for your goodies.

Dervish & Banges

Dervish & Banges is the main shop for Harry Potter souvenirs, including robes, broomsticks, t-shirts, ties, hats, and more. The shop is very, very small and gets crazy crowded, so if you plan to buy some goodies or check this store out, you may want to do so first thing in the morning or later in the evening.

Some cool things to note in the store include the broomsticks hovering above the cashiers and the monster book in a cage as you enter from Owl Post. If you're lucky, the store will have the same broomsticks as those hovering above in stock and stored right behind the cash registers. They sell out fast, in spite of being very pricey ($275-$300).

Hogwart's Castle

In spite of being the queue line for Harry Potter and the Forbidden Journey, Hogwart's Castle is an attraction in and of itself. In order to take in this "attraction," you must go through the whole queue, not the single rider line. You'll miss almost the entire castle if you go single rider.

During your wait, you'll see a Griffin statute, Dumbledore's office, the Dark Arts classroom, lots of talking portraits, and the sorting hat. It's really quite an experience

and in some ways, better than the ride at the end of the line. I often hope for a long line, just so I can take my time and enjoy all the castle has to offer.

Filch's Emporium

Ahh, good old Filch and his confiscated goods. You can enter this shop in two different ways. Either as the exit from Harry Potter and the Forbidden Journey or you can take the path to the right of the Forbidden Journey queue line that leads to the front door of Filch's.

Filch's houses a lot of typical souvenirs -- t-shirts, hats, and so on. You can also get a few unique items, here including the Marauder's Map, lanyards for each Hogwart's house, and the Tri-Wizard wand collection. It's also where Forbidden Journey riders pick up their photos. The shop connects directly to the lockers for the Forbidden Journey ride -- something a lot of first timers miss and end up walking all the way out and around into the queue for the line to get back to their stuff. TIP: You can use this entrance to the lockers to skip the line to put your stuff into lockers for the Forbidden Journey ride that often stretches into the Jurassic Park island!

DINING

Three Broomsticks

This restaurant is a spitting image from the latest Harry Potter movie, Harry Potter and the Half Blood Prince. It is amazing! Three Broomsticks is a counter-service restaurant, but with healthy choices. The author of the Harry Potter books, JK Rowling, wanted there to be a certain amount of calories in each entree to keep the foods served in this area more healthy. The menu boards are a one of a kind, too. These are digital menu boards, which are a first of its kind in the theme park restaurant business. The menu includes items like fish and chips, shepherd's pie, ribs, chicken, and more.

After you pick up your food, try to sit towards the middle of the restaurant. If you look up, you will see doors close and shadows in Three Broomsticks. You can even sit outside for a more intimate setting and this is often a way to get your food and seated more quickly, if you're willing to eat outside in the shade.

Something to note: Three Broomsticks also serves butterbeer! Usuallly, the wait to get into Three Broomsticks is shorter than the line for the butterbeer cart in Diagon Alley. Shocking, but true. Get your butterbeer from Three Broomsticks instead of the

cart to save some time.

Hogshead

Connected to Three Broomsticks, the Hogshead bar offers a variety of refreshments, including the adult varieties. Be sure to watch the hog's head mounted on the wall behind the bar. He'll begin moving his head around grumbling and groaning. It's pretty cool! There's also a separate door to Hogshead, although on busy days (all of them, so far) it will become an exit only door.

Butterbeer Barrel

You won't miss the giant red keg of butterbeer in the middle of Diagon Alley as you wander through Hogsmeade Village. Nor will you miss the line to get the sweet butterbeer concoction. Said to be a mix between shortbread cookies and cream soda, you can get butterbeer in either frozen or cold varieties. I enjoy the frozen much better, as do most reviewers and guests, but it is much sweeter than the cold version. So, if you're not much of a sweet tooth, you may prefer cold to frozen. It's fun to get the butterbeer from the barrel in the street, but this is often the longest wait to try the quaff. Additionally, they only sell butterbeer, here. No food or other drinks.

Food Carts

You'll notice the food carts spread throughout Hogsmeade Village. Often in different locations each day. Usually, there's one in the courtyard in front of Dragon Challenge and across from Ollivander's.

The carts offer drinks (although you won't find sodas anywhere in the Wizarding World) including pumpkin juice, snacks, and even some veggies to snack on. Don't expect to find butterbeer, here though. Occasionally, you'll find a "serving wench" wandering near the carts selling butterbeer, but you better have cash ready as they seldom accept credit.

RIDES

Harry Potter and the Forbidden Journey

The most anticipated and the only new ride in Wizarding World of Harry Potter takes you on a broomstick ride through the grounds of Hogwart's, onto the quidditch field, and some other darker themed areas. It's a much longer ride than most. It's also pretty scary in parts -- something to keep in mind for younger riders. You must be at

least 48" to ride, but my six year old meets this requirement and I wouldn't let him ride it.

Another thing to note, the ride vehicle is very tight! If the safety bar won't click in three positions deep, you won't be allowed to ride. There's a test ride vehicle before you get to the front of the line, but it's well into the queue line. You could wait for an hour before being able to test out the fit. I'm 6'0" and 200 lbs. and it's a very tight fit -- just to give you a point of reference.

No bags are allowed on the ride and you're encouraged to stow all your belongings, as you will get tossed around a bit and could lose things out of your pockets. There's storage lockers that are free for an hour at the door to Hogwart's, on your right as you enter. Remember: you can go through Filch's to get to the lockers and skip the often long line waiting just to get to the lockers.

The ride does not currently have a Universal Express option, but likely will in the future. However, it does have a single rider line that can significantly reduce your wait time. Please note: you will miss most of Hogwart's Castle in the single rider line. Also, use this line only if you truly will ride as a single. The cast members will not put you together just because you got into the single rider line as a group.

One more issue with the single rider line -- you tend to get stuck on the end of a group of three, so you end up in the same seat, every time. Why does this matter? The "show" part of the ride changes depending on which seat you sit in, due to the change in vantage point. Not a big deal, but it's a very different experience in each seat.

Dragon Challenge

Dragon Challenge is the old Dueling Dragons. I had the pleasure of working on the construction of the queue building for Dueling Dragons and was said to see it change over to Harry Potter, but they did a fantastic job with it. The building remains, only the interior has been re-themed for Harry Potter. They have the floating candles in the Forbidden Journey ride, but they did a much better job with it, here. You can see the WEasley's flying Ford Anglia on the left, right before you enter the building.

It's always best to ride this coaster from the front row, as there are several close calls with the other coaster that you'd miss from any other seat. However, it can be a long wait for the front row and it's a thrilling ride from any row.

Flight of the Hippogriff

Although the old Flying Unicorn coaster is supposed to be a coaster for children, it has it's share of thrills. The theming added for the Wizarding World of Harry Potter is awesome! You have a hippogriff in a nest right at the start of the coaster. The queue

line offers a great view of the hippogriff's nest that looks to be constructed from actual tree branches to give it amazing authenticity. You can also see Hagrid's Hut from the queue line.

The ride does have Universal Express, although I'm not sure you need it, as the lines have not been long, even on busy days. The kids love it and you get a great view of Hogsmeade Village from the top of the first climb.

TIPS AND TRICKS!

- Use the single rider line at Harry Potter and the Forbidden Journey. This can significantly reduce the wait time for this ride.
- Store your bags in the lockers at the front of the island. Most of the rides do not allow bags. Save time in line and just put them in these lockers for the day.
- Take advantage of outdoor seating at Three Broomsticks. It's shaded and provides a nice view of the rest of Islands of Adventure. You'll significantly reduce your time waiting to put in your order.
- Use designated "waiters" for the Ollivander's line. This line is all outdoors and easily accessible by people. While one person waits in the line, others can go shop, hit other rides, and so on. You could even switch off, so no one has to wait the full time.
- Speaking of wands, you don't have to wait in that line if you just want to buy a wand! I've been shocked at the number of people that think you must wait in that line to buy a wand. Go into Owl Post through the front door or through Dervish & Banges.
- If you decide not to store your bags in the front lockers, go through Filch's Emporium to store them for the Forbidden Journey ride and avoid the line to stow bags. Filch's has a back entrance to the Forbidden Journey lockers.
- Did you know there's no soda in the Wizarding World of Harry Potter? That's right. If you need your soda fix, pick them up in Lost Continent or Jurassic Park before getting to this island.
- Buy butterbeer in Three Broomsticks. The wait is almost always shorter here than at the butterbeer barrel in Diagon Alley.
- Come in the late afternoon and evening. Everyone's so excited about the new park that it's packed in the morning. However, it doesn't take all day to see everything, so most people are moving on to other attractions in the late afternoon. Wizarding World stays open as long as Islands of Adventure is open, so hit the rest of the park in the morning and come to Wizarding World, later.
- In line with the previous tip, the shops stay open until the lines for Forbidden Journey close. This means you can shop while everyone's getting that last ride in, late at night.

- Use the back door to Dervish & Banges. D & B has a main door in the Owlery, but it also has a back door in the Dragon Challenge exit queue. It drops you right by the goodies and the cashiers. No need to fight the crowds.
- Visit the bathroom, even if you don't have to "go." Get a visit from Moaning Myrtle while finding relief.
- Bring cash! You never know when a "serving wench" will pop up selling butterbeer and like most of this profession, they only accept cash.
- Buy your souvenirs before you leave home. This will keep you on budget, deter impulse buying, and you can wrap them up and give them to your kids as gifts when you arrive in Orlando. This really adds a fun dimension to your vacation, rather than fighting over a trinket in the park and ruining the whole souvenir experience.
- Save $90! If you're staying at a Disney World resort, you can buy the 1 day/2 park pass with shuttle transfers from DestinationsInFlorida.com and get a free shuttle bus to Universal Orlando. This will save you $90 in transportation costs.
- Add Universal Express to your tickets. The only way you'll effectively see two parks in one day is to add the Universal Express option to your tickets. This add-on gives you front of the line access to many of the popular rides at Universal Orlando. Use it effectively and you'll be done by dinner. Get it early, though. Universal caps the number of Express passes they sell and when they're gone, they're gone.
- Universal Meal Deal. If you plan to be in the parks all day and didn't bring all your meals with you, this is a great option for savings! Three Broomsticks is not included in the restaurants, at this time, but you can just grab a snack or butterbeer from Three Broomsticks, get the experience, and still save money.
- Get free breakfast! If you book the Wizarding World of Harry Potter vacation package with DestinationsInFlorida.com, you get free breakfast at Three Broomsticks.
- Upgrade your tickets to the 14-day Flex Pass. If you're going to be vacationing for more than 7 days, this pass will bring your daily ticket cost down below $20 per day for Universal Orlando, Sea World, and Busch Gardens.